country. Therefore, it is of utmost importance that we select, train and groom the best officers and men or women to lead Indian armed forces of the future.

As the army chief, I tried my best to see that promotions, postings and appointments were based on performance, merit and qualifications, without extraneous influences playing any part. Yet there might have been some aberrations. For example, there were some very fine officers of my regiment and others who had served with me earlier, who got left out purely because of relative merit. Yet nothing gave me greater joy and satisfaction than giving a fair deal and a redress to any officer who was unjustly 'fixed' or bypassed for reasons other than professional. By and large, I can say with confidence, most of us have gotten a fair deal. Further, there is no perfect organization in the world. A few 'parasites' would anyhow worm their way into the best of them! And that brings me to my conviction that anyone with a perfect or near-perfect dossier needs to be looked at with suspicion or caution; some of these individuals could be frauds in disguise. Amongst them one is likely to find some very clever 'careerists', who are either great manipulators or individuals who have been fooling the system by taking the help of benign seniors, having served in personal appointments with those high-ranking officers in their early years, or are related to them. The system should be able to pick up such individuals, and sideline them before they reach senior ranks and damage the organization. Based on my personal experience and that of many others, it is my conviction that our armed forces do not write off a 'good guy' in a hurry. At the same time, I do admit that there have been a few genuinely deserving officers who got left out, despite the checks and balances in the system – they were victims of circumstances, I suppose.

There is no alternative to regimental service and command of troops for an officer of the combat arms in particular and all other officers in general. Handling of men, weapon systems and other equipment in different operational situations, terrain configurations, peacetime soldiering and training for war, is in itself a great learning experience. The essentials of leadership that are imbibed